continued unabated, on account of which we had already suffered 35-plus killed and 150-plus injured, not to mention casualties to civilians and damage to their property and livestock. The topic of the Tour of Duty, unofficially called the 'Agnipath Scheme', which had been under formulation for some time, also came up, and I expressed my reservations on certain aspects of the scheme.[22] As usual in the end, the PM had some stories of his own. If in the last interaction, it was about the kite industry in Gujarat, this time it was about railway lines, more specifically, new railway lines. In every Budget, he said, we announce new lines to the middle of nowhere, spending crores of rupees and finally only about fifty people use that facility. He was candid enough to admit that he too had once been part of such a crowd, waving red flags and making such demands. That has always been his refrain—a lack of vision and wasteful expenditure. Just as I was leaving, a googly: '*Meri bhi ek beti Army mein hain, lekin kisi ko batana mat*' (I too have a daughter in the Army, but don't tell anyone). True to his wishes, I did not make any inquiries, though I did come to know later that it was his niece.

The ninth round was held on 24 January 2021. When this round commenced, we were ready to dig in our heels, but the PLA commenced the talks by agreeing to pull back beyond Finger 8 and restore all land forms. This was a pleasant surprise for us and a major breakthrough. All that remained was to prepare a detailed phase-wise, time-bound plan for each of the locations—North Bank, South Bank and Kailash Range. The minutes of the meeting were prepared and signed by the Military Commanders of either side. This itself was a departure from past practice. When this point had first been raised of keeping formal records, the MEA was not too keen, as border talks came under their remit. However, in the absence of proper records or minutes, it was difficult to move forward. Now, since

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